“The duration of the contract is no longer a year.” He touched his collar. “It’s until the war ends.”

“How long could that be?” she asked.

“We don’t know. You mustn’t feel compelled—”

“What does Rose think?” Léa wanted to speak to her sister, get her advice.

“She says it’s up to you and whatever you do, she’ll support it.”

“Is that what she said?” He nodded. Léa hesitated. “I need more time to think—”

He checked his watch. “The train leaves in three hours.”

“For Germany?”

“Yes.” He put the pen on the table and slid the paper over to her. “Read the contract. Ask any question, and I’ll do my best to answer. Rose waits for you at the station—she went to pack a suitcase with your things.”

She wished Rose was here so she could look into her sister’s eyes and know it was the right decision. But in her heart, Léa felt she had no other choice. She flipped to the last page and scratched her signature above the line where her name had been typed.

“You must read it in full. Your future depends—”

“If you believe I should go, I trust you.”

“Initial the bottom right corner of each page, confirming you’ve read and understood.” He cleared his throat. “Léa, if you need to reconsider—”

“You said we didn’t have much time.” She initialed the pages, then handed him the pen. “Let’s go to Rose. I have to see her to say goodbye before I leave.”

Standing, he showed the contract to the gendarme. More papers appeared for them to sign.

“Now, we can go,” Maître Mallon said, returning to the table after conversing with the gendarme. Maître Mallon glanced at his watch. “If we hurry, you’ll make the train.”

A slight panic at the back of her throat. “Rose is at the station?” She couldn’t leave without saying goodbye to her.

“Yes.”

She followed him out the door to the bicycles. He mounted one and gestured for her to take the other, and they pedaled side by side on the towpath along the Loire. The ride to Orléans took three quarters of an hour.